ignored the Nazi menace, choosing instead to denounce the SPD as ‘1,000 times worse than an open fascist dictatorship’, and reminding voters that without the support of the SPD, Germany would have been unable to make war in 1914. Ernst Thälmann, the thickset, balding KPD leader, failed to trigger adequate alarm by declaring ‘some Nazi trees must not be allowed to overshadow a forest of Social Democrats’.7 Even graver accusations, first made in 1924, were reheated. The KPD charged the SPD with making Germany a paradise for capitalists and speculators.

Social democracy appears under the mask of a workers’ party. It has promised a thousand times to represent the interests of the exploited, and a thousand times it has betrayed the masses of the working people to German and foreign big business. The Social Democrats have always stabbed the fighting proletarian in the back … Social Democracy must be defeated so that it no longer dares to call itself a workers’ party…

In the KPD calculus, the Nazis were less sophisticated and thus less dangerous than the SPD. It was a major strategic miscalculation, and Hitler benefited greatly from the inability of the KPD and SPD to cooperate. After a noisy propaganda campaign for the 1932 presidential elections, the incumbent, Paul von Hindenburg, kept his position, and Ernst Thälmann managed to snatch 13.2 per cent of the vote, compared to Hitler’s 30.1 per cent. Throughout, the KPD was swamped in the preparations for a propaganda blitz, and cadres, including Honecker, were key to transporting their message. In addition to speeches, the communists were helped by technical innovations like cheaper printing, which helped flood the market with illustrated pamphlets and posters. In the federal elections – in which Honecker was involved in intense campaigning – the KPD won 16 per cent of the vote, coming third. Honecker remembered it was the last time ‘I saw our unforgettable Ernst Thälmann, the first and last time that I was able to talk to him personally.’8